

CELTS



PROUD WARRIORS AND SKILLED METALWORKERS, the Celts were among Europe's oldest peoples. The first tribes lived in central European hillforts, but by 400 BC, they also dominated the British Isles, Spain, Italy, and France, and even pushed on into western Asia. Unique and decorative Celtic arts spread with their mythology and religion via trade routes, but the Celts showed no interest in building an empire, or even unifying all their territories. By 50 BC, the mighty Romans and Germanic peoples had squeezed the Celts into Europe's fringes, where they converted to Christianity. Today, Celtic culture and languages survive in Ireland, Scotland, Wales, and parts of France and England.

Celtic society

Celtic tribes were made up of three main classes: warriors, druids, and farmers. Warfare was an important part of life, so the warriors, armed with their sophisticated iron weaponry, formed an aristocracy. Druids were religious leaders, who often held the power of life and death over other tribe members. Farmers, who reared cattle and cultivated crops using iron tools, kept the economy going. Celts lived in fortified camps called hillforts. Though built for defence, hillforts were also places of trade and religious worship – some even grew into towns. Each pagan Celtic tribe had its own king, and maybe even its own gods. Skilled metalworkers probably had high status.



Celtic hillfort

Celtic horse

The horse played a major part in early Celtic warfare and religion. A horse-goddess called Pegasus was worshipped first by the Celts, but then also by cavalrymen in the Roman army. There are several chalk figures cut into the rock in former Celtic areas. Some resemble the horse figures that appear on surviving Celtic coins.



Druids

The druids were holy men in pagan Celtic society. The earliest record of them was made by Julius Caesar, who reported that they acted as judges, led rituals in forest clearings, and used golden sickles to cut mistletoe from sacred oak trees. Druids were skilled in herbalism, and kept oral records of their tribe's history. Occasionally, they performed human and animal sacrifices. Those wanting to become druids had to study for up to 20 years.



Oak leaves

Ritual

The druids left no written records, so their rituals are shrouded in mystery. Celts worshipped many gods and spirits, particularly of trees, rocks, and mountains. One of the oldest gods, Cernunnos, is known as the lord of the beasts. He is often portrayed either wearing antlers or with horned animals, such as stags. He is also often shown wearing golden torcs, and seems to represent fertility and abundance.

Stags are often shown with Cernunnos.

Horned animals symbolize aggression and vitality.



Detail from Gundestrup Cauldron



A stone head with three faces is called a triple head.

Cult of the head

The human head was very important to the pagan Celts, as was the number "3". One custom was to cut the head off a dead enemy, hang it from a horse bridle, then put it on public display. This may have been because the druids believed that a person's soul was in his head, and had to be mastered.

Boudicca

Boudicca (d.61 AD) was queen of the Iceni, one of Britain's Celtic tribes. When the Romans conquered Britain after 43 AD, the Iceni joined forces with them to defeat a rival tribe. However, the Romans then seized Iceni lands and flogged Boudicca. She led a huge revolt, destroying the Roman settlements at St. Albans, Colchester, and London. The Romans finally defeated the rebels, and Queen Boudicca killed herself by taking poison rather than risk being captured.

